plausibly dressed as a sixteenth-century European ambassador despite being a charlatan. In the midst of one of the most cosmopolitan and opulent courts in the world, in which the men would have been wearing flowing jamas in the finest of materials, delicately embroidered and jewelled, Mildenhall would have been a study in stiffness and angles. He would have been wearing hose and breeches on his lower body to present his calves to their full advantage, male legs at the time being a particular measure of beauty. He would have been wearing a doublet, and a padded overshirt, and outsized, attached sleeves. The piece de resistance of this outfit would have been the frilled ruff around the neck that had recently become de rigueur for men and women of fashion, and perhaps even a mandilion, or cloak, draped negligently over one shoulder. Luckily for all concerned, the codpiece had recently gone out of favour.

When Mildenhall submitted his request for England to be granted the same trading privileges as Portugal, and to be allowed, in addition, to attack Portuguese ships if required, Akbar listened to the Englishman carefully and then sent for the Jesuits. After Akbar's conference with the Jesuits, 'whereas before we were friends', wrote Mildenhall about his relationship with the court, 'now we grew to be exceeding great enemies'. Not surprisingly, the Jesuits, who were always working in accord with the commercial and secular arm of the Portuguese enterprise at Goa, would have been aghast at this English Protestant interloper. When Akbar asked them about the matter, wrote Mildenhall, 'they flatly answered him that our nation were all thieves and that I was a spy, sent thither for no other purpose to have friendship with his Majesty but that afterward our men might come thither and get some of his ports, and so put His Majesty to much trouble'.

When Mildenhall grew upset at the Jesuits' intemperate language, Akbar spoke to him kindly, told him not to be sad, and sent for fine European garments for him from his own wardrobe. Mildenhall waited for months for trade concessions. All this while, he wrote, the Jesuits 'day and night sought how to work my displeasure'. According to the Englishman, the Jesuits bribed Mughal officers with large sums of money and attempted to sully his reputation and his honour with all those who were well disposed towards him. They even lured away Mildenhall's translator, an Armenian who had worked with him for four years. Pinheiro, especially, described as 'a thoroughly unscrupulous man', worked tirelessly to discredit Mildenhall.